M365-04 · Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard

How mail reaches a group of people at the organization, how dynamic membership is derived from the HR and user system of record, and what IT will not build.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-04
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 3 — Expert Services. Membership rules and directory attributes are Tier 3 architecture.
Review cycle	Annually, and whenever a directory attribute is committed to a new purpose.

1. Purpose

This standard states how mail reaches a group of people, which kind of object serves which purpose, and how dynamic membership is derived. It exists because that explanation is so often delivered by email, repeatedly, to a different audience each time.

The usual pattern is a long email thread that gets forwarded on because it “explains a lot” about how the dynamic groups were made, and the information in it is clear. That is precisely the problem. Clear information delivered by email is not published, cannot be cited, and has to be re-sent.

> **What a published standard changes**
>
> It gives IT something to point at instead of re-explaining, and it gives a department a way to find the answer without asking. Both matter more in an understaffed team than in a well-staffed one, because re-explaining is the cost nobody counts.
>
> It also makes declining a request defensible. A typical case: a department asks for a new dynamic group, and the directory attribute it needs has already been committed to the ticketing system. Declining is the right call, and it is very hard to explain when the constraint is not written down anywhere.

2. Scope

- Distribution lists, mail-enabled security groups, Microsoft 365 groups and dynamic distribution groups.
- How dynamic membership rules are written and which source attributes they may use.

- The register of directory attributes and what each is committed to. Out of scope: shared mailboxes, which are M365-03; Teams, which are M365-07; security groups used purely for access rather than mail, which follow ACC-02 §3 naming and are governed by the document granting the access; broadcast mail to the whole organization, which is M365-06.

3. The four things people mean by “a group”

Object	Use it to	Membership	Watch out for
Distribution list	Send mail to a fixed set of people who do not change often.	Manual, maintained by a named owner.	Goes stale silently. Needs the §10 review or it slowly becomes wrong.
Dynamic distribution group	Send mail to everyone matching a rule — all staff, everyone in one region.	Calculated at send time from directory attributes.	Only as good as the underlying data. A person with a wrong attribute is silently excluded.
Mail-enabled security group	Both grant access and send mail to the same set.	Manual or dynamic.	Convenient and risky: changing the mail list changes who has access. Prefer separate objects.
Microsoft 365 group	Give a team a shared identity across Teams, SharePoint and a group mailbox.	Manual or dynamic.	Creates a Team and a site whether or not anyone wanted them (M365-07).

Appendix A is this table as a decision path. Most requests that arrive as “can we have a group for X” are answered by a dynamic distribution group or by an alias, and neither is what the requester asked for by name.

4. Naming

Type	Pattern
Dynamic, population-wide	A plain descriptive address, for example allstaff@yourdomain.
Distribution list, departmental	dept-@yourdomain
Distribution list, committee or project	grp-@yourdomain
Security group for access	ROLE--, per ACC-02 §4.2 — visually distinct from anything mail-enabled.
Microsoft 365 group / Team	Per M365-07.

One rule: a group name describes who is in it, never who currently leads it or what the current project is called. Names outlive both, and a name that has become wrong is worse than an ugly one because people trust it.

Note a genuine platform constraint worth recording: a Microsoft 365 group naming policy does not apply to dynamic distribution groups, and Exchange distribution-group naming policy is configured separately. So naming here is enforced by procedure rather than by the platform, which means §11 review is the only thing keeping it true.

5. Who may request what

Request	Requested by	Approved by
A departmental distribution list	Department head or delegate	Tier 2
A committee or project list	The chair or project lead	Tier 2
A dynamic group over an existing attribute	Any department head	Tier 3
A dynamic group needing a NEW attribute	Department head	Tier 4 — see §7. This is the expensive one.
Any group addressing the whole organization or a whole population	Department head	Tier 4, under M365-06
A cohort group defined by something the HR and user system of record does not record	Anyone	Declined, with §8 as the reason

6. Dynamic groups — how membership is actually derived

This is the section that answers most of the questions in that kind of email thread.

1. The HR and user system of record holds the authoritative record for every person. Directory attributes are populated from it.
2. A dynamic group holds a rule against those attributes, not a list of people. Nobody is “added to” a dynamic group, and asking IT to add somebody to one is asking for something that does not exist as an operation.
3. Membership is evaluated when mail is sent. So a correction to somebody’s record in the HR and user system of record fixes their group membership — and, equally, a wrong record silently excludes them with no error anywhere.
4. Which means: when a person is missing from a population group, the fault is almost never the group. It is the record. Fix the record (ACC-01 Rule 1).

> **The two misunderstandings worth pre-empting**
>
> First: “add this person to employees@”. Not possible, and not a limitation — it is what makes the group trustworthy. If they belong in it, their record says so.
>
> Second: an alias on a group is not a second group. Adding sales-team@ as an alias of dept-sales@ does not create a different membership; it is the same list reachable by two addresses. This is the commonest alias confusion, and §9 addresses it directly.

One technical caution for whoever writes the rules: RecipientType and RecipientTypeDetails are different, and a rule filtering on RecipientType will silently include shared mailboxes alongside user mailboxes. Filter on RecipientTypeDetails where only real people are wanted. This is a common and quiet error.

7. The attribute register

Directory extension attributes are a finite resource. Each one can serve exactly one purpose, and once committed it cannot serve another without breaking whatever depends on it.

This is the usual reason a dynamic group request gets declined: the attribute it needs has already been committed elsewhere. Declining is correct, and it is hard to explain when no register exists. Section 8 is the polite version of the answer; this section is what makes it checkable.

1. IT maintains a register of every directory attribute, what it holds, what populates it, and what depends on it. Appendix B is the template.
2. No attribute is committed to a new purpose without a Tier 4 decision recorded against M365-21.
3. Before promising any dynamic group, Tier 3 checks the register. A promise made and then withdrawn costs more than a slow answer.
4. Where the register shows no attribute available, the answer is §8 — and now it comes with a reason the requester can see.

8. What IT will not build, and why

Saying this in a published standard is kinder than saying it per request, and it lets departments plan.

IT will not build	Because
A group defined by something the HR and user system of record does not record	There is no source for the membership, so it would have to be maintained by hand forever and would be wrong within months.
A dynamic group requiring a new attribute, without a Tier 4 decision	Attributes are finite and committing one silently breaks the next request (§7).
A manual list of more than about fifty people	It will go stale and nobody will notice. Use a dynamic group over an attribute that already exists, or accept that it needs a named owner and a review.
A group duplicating one that already exists with slightly different membership	Two nearly-identical lists guarantee that some announcements reach one and not the other, which is worse than one imperfect list.
A list allowing anyone to mail an entire population unmoderated	That is M365-06 and needs approval, not a group.
A group whose purpose is to bypass another department's approval	Stated plainly because it happens, and it puts IT in the middle of something that is not a technical dispute.

Where IT declines, it offers the alternative that does work — an alias, an existing group, a moderated broadcast, or a conversation with whoever owns the data. Declining without an alternative is how departments learn to route around IT.

9. Aliases are not groups

The clearest single point of confusion in the record, and worth stating in isolation.

An alias	A second address that delivers to the same place. Free, instant, and reversible. Does not change membership, permissions, or who receives anything.
A group	An object with its own membership. Delivers to a set of people determined by that membership.
So	If a department wants mail to a new address to reach the same people, that is an alias and takes minutes (M365-05). If they want it to reach different people, that is a new group and needs §5.

When a request arrives, the diagnostic question is simply: should this reach exactly the same people, or different people? Everything follows from the answer, and asking it first avoids most of the thread.

10. Review

1. Manual distribution lists are reviewed annually by their named owner. An unreviewed list is deprecated after two missed reviews and its owner told.
2. Dynamic groups do not need membership review, but their rules do — annually, and whenever the underlying attribute changes meaning.
3. The attribute register is reviewed annually and whenever a system is retired. A tool retiring in favour of Intune, for instance, may free the attribute that blocked a department's request — which is worth knowing.

11. Service levels

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
An alias on an existing group or mailbox	P3 — usually same day. Frequently the real answer.
A new manual distribution list, owner named	P3 — acknowledged within 1 coverage day.
A dynamic group over an existing attribute	P3 at Tier 3 — acknowledged within 1 coverage day, delivered against Tier 3 capacity.
A dynamic group needing a new attribute	P4 — a Tier 4 decision first. Do not promise a date before that decision.
"Somebody is missing from a population group"	P3 — and treated as a record correction, not a group change (§6).

12. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Attribute register	IT register	Live document — the important one
Group register: name, type, purpose, owner, rule, review date	IT register	Live document

Record	Held in	Retention
Requests and approvals, including declines with reasons	Ticket	3 years
Tier 4 attribute commitment decisions	Change record against M365-21	Permanent
Annual review confirmations	Ticket	3 years

13. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
M365-03	Shared Mailbox Request, Provisioning & Ownership	The other object people mean when they say “group”.
M365-05	Email Alias & Address Change Standard	Section 9. Frequently the actual answer.
M365-06	Mass Communication & Broadcast Email Approval	Where whole-population mail goes.
M365-07	Teams Provisioning, Naming & Lifecycle	Microsoft 365 groups create Teams and sites.
M365-21	Tenant Configuration Change Control	Records attribute commitments (§7).
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	Rule 1 — the HR and user system of record as the system of record, which §6 depends on entirely.
ACC-02	Account Naming Standard	ROLE- security group naming.
GOV-06	Service Commitments	Supplies §11.

Appendix A — Which object do I need?

Work down. Stop at the first line that matches.

	Do you want to...	Then
1	Reach exactly the same people as an existing address, via a new address	An alias (M365-05). Minutes, not a project.
2	Have several people answer mail sent to one published address	A shared mailbox (M365-03).
3	Send mail to everyone matching a fact the HR and user system of record already records	A dynamic distribution group. Tier 3.
4	Send mail to a fixed set of people you will maintain yourself	A distribution list, with you as named owner.

	Do you want to…	Then
5	Give a team files, chat and a shared identity	A Team (M365-07).
6	Both grant access and send mail to the same people	Two objects, not one. Ask Tier 3.
7	Reach a cohort defined by something the HR and user system of record does not record	Not possible as a dynamic group — see §8. Ask what the HR and user system of record does record; there is often a workable proxy.
8	Mail an entire population	M365-06. Needs approval, not a group.

Appendix B — Attribute register

Fill this in from your own directory. The directory can tell you what is in each attribute and how many accounts hold a value; it cannot tell you who decided to put it there, so the last two columns are filled in by hand.

Attribute	Accounts with a value	Values observed	Populated by	Status
extensionAttribute1				IN USE / THIN / FREE
extensionAttribute2				
extensionAttribute3				
… one row per attribute, up to 15				
extensionAttribute15				

> **What to look for once it is filled in**
>
> HOW MANY ARE COMMITTED. If most of the fifteen are in use, every request for a “new attribute” becomes a conversation about which one to reclaim, and you can now say so with a number.
>
> THINLY USED ATTRIBUTES. An attribute holding values for only a handful of accounts is effectively free. Reclaim it deliberately, with a change record, rather than by overwriting it.
>
> MISSPELLED VALUES. A rule written against the correct spelling returns zero members if the source data is misspelled, and the author assumes the rule is wrong. Correct the source or document the misspelling.
>
> PARTIAL COVERAGE. An attribute populated for only part of the population silently excludes everyone else from any group built on it. Confirm coverage before promising a group.
>
> ENABLED ACCOUNTS WITH NO ATTRIBUTES. A large gap between enabled accounts and accounts with attribute values often means enabled accounts belonging to people who have left — the condition ACC-12 and ACC-17 exist to prevent.

Keep this register current, and answer the next dynamic group request from it. It is the difference between “no, because this many attributes are committed and here is the register” and “no”.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.